The Trees

The big idea

The Trees by **Adrienne Rich** describes potted or indoor trees moving out of a house back into the **empty forest**. On the surface it is about nature reclaiming its space; at a deeper level it is about **freedom** — especially of women breaking out of confinement.

Stanza-wise summary

1. **The empty forest:** The trees inside the house are **moving out into the forest**, which has been empty all these days — no bird could sit there, no insect could hide, the sun could not "bury its feet in shadow". By morning, the forest will be full again.
2. **The struggle to escape:** All night the **roots** work to disengage themselves from the cracks in the veranda floor; the **leaves** strain toward the glass; small **twigs** are stiff with exertion; the long-cramped **boughs** shuffle under the roof **like newly discharged patients**, half-dazed, moving to the clinic doors.
3. **The indifferent poet:** The poet sits inside with the doors open to the veranda, **writing long letters** in which she scarcely mentions the departure of the forest from the house. The night is fresh, the whole moon shines in a sky still open, and the smell of leaves and lichen reaches like a voice into the rooms.
4. **The escape:** Her head is full of whispers which tomorrow will be silent. She hears the **glass breaking** as the trees stumble forward into the night. The **wind rushes to meet them**. The **moon is broken like a mirror**, and its pieces flash in the crown of the tallest oak.

TWO LEVELS OF MEANING

- **Literal:** trees kept indoors by humans long for their natural home; without trees the forest is lifeless.
- **Symbolic:** the trees stand for **women** confined to the home by a patriarchal society, struggling to break free and claim their place in the world.

Poetic devices

- **Personification:** trees moving out, roots working, twigs stiff with exertion, boughs shuffling, wind rushing to meet them.
- **Simile:** "**like newly discharged patients**"; "the moon is broken **like a mirror**"; smell reaching "**like a voice**".
- **Metaphor:** "sun bury its feet in shadow".
- **Imagery:** visual (moon, glass breaking), olfactory (smell of leaves and lichen), auditory (glass breaking, whispers).
- **Symbolism:** trees (women/freedom), house (confinement), forest (freedom), broken moon (shattered old order).
- **Free verse** with **enjambment**.

THE POET DOES NOT HELP OR STOP THE TREES

She stays indoors writing letters and barely mentions the departure — this shows **detachment** or perhaps her own silent wish for freedom.

Message and value points

- Nature needs its freedom; cutting trees or caging nature makes the earth barren.
- Everyone, especially women, deserves freedom and an identity of their own.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why is the forest empty? What do the roots, leaves and twigs do? Explain "like newly discharged patients". What does the broken moon suggest? What is the symbolic meaning of the poem?

Quick recap

- Adrienne Rich; free verse.
- Trees move from the house to the empty forest.
- Similes: discharged patients; moon like a mirror.
- Themes: nature reclaiming its place; women's freedom.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "The Trees"?
   (a) Robin Klein (b) Adrienne Rich (c) Carl Sandburg (d) W.B. Yeats
2. Why was the forest empty?
   (a) There were no trees, so no bird could sit and no insect hide (b) It had been burnt (c) The animals had been hunted (d) It was winter
3. The boughs shuffling under the roof are compared to
   (a) prisoners in jail (b) children at school (c) soldiers on parade (d) newly discharged patients
4. What is the poet doing while the trees move out?
   (a) Cutting the trees (b) Calling for help (c) Writing long letters (d) Sleeping
5. "The moon is broken like a mirror" is an example of
   (a) metaphor (b) simile (c) alliteration (d) onomatopoeia
6. Symbolically, the trees represent
   (a) old buildings (b) women breaking free from confinement (c) soldiers going to war (d) the poet's letters
7. "The Trees" can be read both as a poem about nature and as a poem about human freedom. Explain.

Answers: 1. b 2. a 3. d 4. c 5. b 6. b 7. see notes